



United States Department of the Interior

FISH AND WILDLIFE SERVICE

Boqueron Field Office
P.O. Box 491
Boqueron, Puerto Rico 00622



March 16, 2000

Ms. Maritza Borges
Planning Director
Highway and Transportation Authority
Department of Transportation and Public Works
P.O. Box 42007
San Juan, Puerto Rico 00940-2007

Re: Bicycle and Pedestrian Trail
Rincon

Dear Ms. Borges:

This is regarding the construction of the Rincón Bicycle and Pedestrian Trail. Based on the information provided, the route starts at PR 115 in the town and runs along existing roads and coastal areas ending at the beach area known as "landing", north to Punta Gorda. The route was visited on March 7, 2000.

As we mentioned in our letter of January 31, 1996, regarding this project, the proposed route is located within the range of the following endangered species:

Plants:

Vahl's boxwood

Buxus vahlia

Animals:

Puerto Rican boa

Epicrates inornatus

Leatherback sea turtle

Dermochelys coriacea

Hawksbill sea turtle

Eretmochelys imbricata

Based on the construction documents and the site visit, no habitat for the Puerto Rican boa nor the boxwood is present along the route. Although the majority of the route is proposed adjacent to existing roads, there are several sections that go through beaches that harbor nesting habitat for the hawksbill sea turtle and leatherback sea turtle. These beaches are located within sections A-3, A-4, A-5, A-7 and A-9. We did not have an opportunity to visit sections A-4, A-5 and A-9.



Yo José Riquelme, funcionario
autorizado por el Secretario(a) del Departamento de
Recursos Naturales y Ambientales.

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Dado en San Juan, Puerto Rico, hoy 23 de Junio
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In order to avoid impacts to sea turtles at the sections we visited, we recommended that the trail be moved to existing dirt roads or trails or set back at least 50 meters above the high tide to eliminate any possible impact to the hawksbill sea turtle habitat. No clearing of coastal vegetation, no construction activity, machinery use, or vehicle traffic should be allowed in these areas. A reforestation program with sea grape and other coastal vegetation is recommended to enhance hawksbill habitat in the area. At section A-7, we recommend that the trail be changed to use the existing dirt road instead of using the beach area. The beach in section A-7 is a pristine pocket beach with a very well developed coastal forest, suitable for nesting for both hawksbill and leatherback sea turtles. We do not recommend the use of the "zona marítimo terrestre" to locate the trail in section A-3 as an alternative to the proposed route. In addition, we understand that no lighting will be installed in the project route.

Since this project will use Federal funds, a section 7 consultation between the funding agency and the Service will be required if possible impacts are not avoided. We are willing to work with the developer and your agency to provide technical assistance for developing measures to avoid impacts to these species. We would like to visit the three sections we could not visit on March 7, 2000.

If you have any questions, please call Marelisa Rivera of my staff.

Sincerely yours



James P. Oland
Field Supervisor

mtr

cc: Arc. Eugenio Fernandez, San Juan
Federal Highways, San Juan



Yo José Aguilar L., funcionario
autorizado por el Secretario(a) del Departamento de
Recursos Naturales y Ambientales.

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